share in the pie. (There were other non-monetary issues as well, to which we will turn later.) Exuding confidence, VOC said the plan was to run two steamers of 3,000 tonnage each, apart from a steam launch. VOC's optimism notwithstanding, the correspondent had his doubts, but nevertheless reported with some objectivity. Most interestingly, at least at this stage, VOC disavowed political objectives. Perhaps he was testing the waters and that could explain the non-hostile tone of the *Times of Ceylon*. Unlike in Bengal, where 'politics was mixed up with the Swadeshi movement', in Tuticorin, VOC emphasized, 'it was a purely national effort to encourage more enterprise among the natives'. He even ventured to assure that the new company would make no attempt to undercut BI by slashing its rates.[6]

The only Tamil daily of the day, G. Subramania Iyer's *Swadesamitran*, picked up the report of the *Times of Ceylon*. Endorsing its avowedly apolitical stance, it remarked that if in Bengal, Swadeshi enterprise was entwined with politics, the blame was due to Lord Curzon's decision to partition Bengal unmindful of popular opinion and sentiment, a situation that did not obtain in the South. Emphasizing that unity was the need of the hour, *Swadesamitran* called upon the Colombo traders to join hands with their Tuticorin counterparts. However, it was more realistic when pointing out—in fact, alerting—that British companies had deep pockets and could bleed their rivals by rate-cutting.[7]

Swadesamitran's editorial was received with enthusiasm by one '*Ilankaivasi*' ('resident of Lanka') to whose letter G. Subramania Iyer added an editorial note: 'We are eager to publish any further information on this noble venture.'[8] He was true to his word: as our footnote references will bear testimony, *Swadesamitran* reported extensively, and with passion, on the fortunes of the Swadeshi company until it breathed its last.[9] There were other responses to the first reports as well. One P.S.P., writing from Palayamkottai—from the heartland of the Swadeshi movement in south India—drew attention to VOC's earlier efforts to promote Swadeshism by acquiring looms to encourage indigenous weaving.[10]